



BEFORE

The Mongol Yuan dynasty was destroyed by economic turmoil and peasant rebellions.

YUAN DRAMA

The earliest Chinese plays, which were sung, spoken, acted, and mimed, were written by Chinese scholars in the Yuan period. Allegedly, the plays contained protests against the Mongol presence, and the popular response to them was said to have contributed to the collapse of the Yuan dynasty.

SUPPRESSION OF THE HAN

According to Mongol law, the indigenous people of China, the Han Chinese, were the lowest class within Chinese society. In the 1340s, a disastrous flood of the Yellow River and the conscription of thousands of Han peasants for forced labour led to widespread rebellion, and the Yuan dynasty was finally overthrown in 1368.

ORIGINS OF THE GREAT WALL

Though the Great Wall that survives today was constructed during the Ming dynasty, its foundations were first laid by Qin Shihuang << 126–27 in 214 BCE, when he connected the fortifications of the small kingdoms of the Warring States era to form a barrier that would defend the empire against barbarians.

The Ming Dynasty

The Ming, the last native Chinese dynasty, replaced the Mongol Yuan dynasty in 1368. During their rule a new capital city was created at Beijing, and the Forbidden City was built within its walls. The Ming period also saw China construct a defensive barrier against the outside world—the Great Wall.

China under the Ming enjoyed relative stability and saw the development of a sophisticated bureaucracy, but also witnessed a period of imperial tyranny. In contrast to some Western nations of the time, where royal authority was challenged, imperial power under the Ming grew unchecked.

Hongwu, the first Ming emperor, began life as a poor peasant. During his reign he reorganized the army and attempted to reform the land and tax system. In 1380, Hongwu abolished the

post of chief minister, revised the legal code, and ensured that imperial power could not be challenged in court. This was supported by a surveillance system operated by spies, secret agents, and the “Brocade Guards,” who carried out major purges of corrupt officials.

Urban growth under Yongle

Hongwu’s son usurped the throne in 1403 and reigned as Emperor Yongle. He transferred the capital to Beijing, and began building a magnificent walled palace complex there, the Forbidden City (see right), which nobody was allowed to enter without permission.

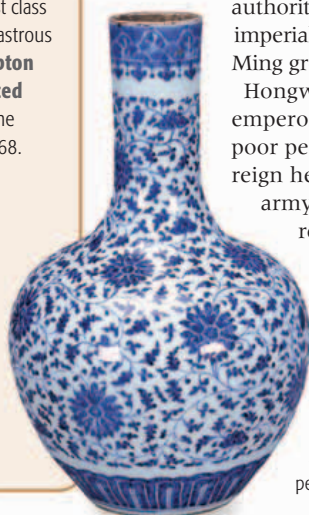
Beijing became the main bureaucratic and military center, but other cities and towns also grew apace. Suzhou and Nanjing became famous for their sophisticated social life and lavish festivals. Jingdezhen turned out blue-and-white porcelain and Hangzhou produced silk. Many of these cities

were connected by the Grand Canal (see p.160); Linqing, one of the main ports on the canal, handled 1.6 million shiploads of freight annually.

A vigorous urban culture accompanied the growth of Ming cities. The spread of printing and the demands of a more literate public led to a publishing boom. Classic novels such as *The Romance of the Three Kingdoms*, *Water Margin*, and *Journey to the West* (otherwise known as *Monkey*) came out for the first time in print, and books with colored wood-block illustrations were published.

Frontier strategy

After Yongle’s death, the Ming dynasty was threatened by a new group of ethnic outsiders—the Mongol-speaking Oirat peoples—who began a massive invasion into Chinese territory in 1449. Emperor Zhengtong rashly counterattacked, but his forces were ambushed at Tumu and he himself was taken hostage. The



Typical Ming vase

The distinctive cobalt blue glaze of Chinese porcelain, developed by the Yuan, was perfected under the Ming.